of capitalism and said it provided an opportunity to all Americans to work, apply themselves, and get ahead; whenever I alluded to the economic problems that by contrast were hounding his country, Gorbachev emphasized that he believed in the Communist system, but he seemed to say mistakes had been made in running it and he was trying to correct them. He was an eloquent debater as well as a good listener, and despite our disagreements, our conversations never turned hostile—he stood his ground and I stood mine.

Later that day, at a plenary session with both our delegations, we went head-to-head again on the Strategic Defense Initiative. Gorbachev, without saying it in so many words, suggested that when I'd made my offer to share our SDI research and open our laboratories to the Soviets so they could see that the SDI was not designed for offensive purposes, I was lying.

No country would do that, he insisted, judging others by his own country. He seemed convinced that I wanted to get a leg up on the Soviets in the arms race and to use the SDI as a cover for an offensive first-strike capability against the Soviet Union. Once again, he was as adamant as I was, and neither of us retreated from our positions.

When I brought up the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, Gorbachev responded that he had known nothing about it personally until he heard a radio broadcast, suggesting that it was a war he had no responsibility—and little enthusiasm—for.

I let him know that, whatever its roots, the people of America regarded Soviet aggression in Afghanistan as an example of a giant country trying to impose its will on a tiny one.

That evening it was our turn to host dinner and I saw, as I had the night before when the Soviets had entertained us, that Gorbachev could be warm and outgoing in a social